PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 08



AMRITSAR ORIGIN

Amritsari Chole

Dark, Tangy Amritsar-Style Chickpeas
The Golden Temple City's Street Food Pride

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Amritsari Chole

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Amritsar's Own Style of Chole

While chole is beloved across North India, Amritsar has cultivated a distinct enough style of its own to earn a name — Amritsari chole is darker, tangier, and more deeply spiced than the more commonly known Delhi-style version, and the city's street food culture treats it as a point of civic pride, with generations-old stalls near the Golden Temple famous specifically for their chole.

The dish's signature dark color comes from a generous simmer with tea leaves or tea bags, a technique used elsewhere in North India but especially associated with Amritsar's version, along with a heavier hand with dried spices like pomegranate seed powder (anardana) and a distinctive dry-roasted whole spice blend rather than a simple wet masala. The result is a chickpea curry with real depth and a slightly sour, almost smoky character that sets it apart.

Its most famous pairing is Amritsari kulcha — a stuffed, tandoor-baked bread distinct from the simpler naan or roti — and the combination of kulcha chole is considered one of Amritsar's defining culinary exports, now found at North Indian restaurants and street stalls far beyond the city itself.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Amritsar's Own Style of Chole, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A civic point of pride in Amritsar, with generations-old street stalls near the Golden Temple famous specifically for their version. Distinguished from other regional chole by its darker color, tangier flavor, and heavier use of dried spice blends. Traditionally paired with Amritsari kulcha, a stuffed tandoor bread distinct from plain naan. A dish deeply tied to Amritsar's identity as a street food destination in its own right, beyond its religious significance as home to the Golden Temple.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	8h + 45m	4	Med
ACTIVE PREP	SOAK + COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker
- Kadai or wide, heavy-bottomed pan
- Small dry pan, for roasting whole spices if making the masala from scratch
- Spice grinder or mortar and pestle

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Amritsari chole keeps refrigerated for up to 4 days and, like most chole preparations, tastes even better the next day. It freezes very well for up to 3 months. Reheat gently with a splash of water to loosen the gravy, and add fresh garnish just before serving.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the chickpeas

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Chickpeas (kabuli chana), dried	1½ cups	300 g	1½ katori
Water, for soaking and cooking	as needed	as needed	as needed
Black tea bags	2–3	2–3	2–3
Whole dried amla (Indian gooseberry) — optional, traditional	2–3 pieces	2–3 pieces	2–3 pieces
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

For the amritsari masala

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Oil or ghee	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Onion, finely chopped	1 large	150 g	1 large
Ginger-garlic paste	1½ tbsp	22 g	1½ chammach
Tomatoes, pureed	2 medium	200 g	2 medium
Anardana powder (dried pomegranate seed)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Amchur (dried mango powder)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Kashmiri red chili powder	1½ tsp	4.5 g	1½ chammach
Amritsari chole masala (dry-roasted whole spice blend)	2 tbsp	12 g	2 tbsp

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the amritsari masala (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste

For garnish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Onion, thinly sliced	½ small	40 g	½ small
Green chili, slit	2	2	2
Fresh ginger, julienned	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Lemon wedges	4	4	4

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Anardana (dried pomegranate seed powder) provides Amritsari chole's distinctive tang and can be found at Indian grocers; if unavailable, extra amchur or a squeeze of lemon at the end approximates the sourness. Dried amla is a traditional but optional addition, primarily for subtle tang and color, easily omitted if unavailable. A good store-bought "Amritsari chole masala" spice blend, sold specifically under that name by several Indian spice brands, is a very acceptable substitute for making the dry-roasted blend from scratch.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Chickpeas

01 SOAK OVERNIGHT

Rinse the dried chickpeas and soak in plenty of water overnight, or at least 8 hours.

02 PRESSURE COOK WITH TEA AND AMLA

Drain and pressure cook with fresh water, salt, tea bags, and dried amla if using, for 6–8 whistles, until completely soft and darkly tinted.



Chef tip. Amritsari chole should be noticeably darker than standard chole — don't skimp on the tea simmering step.

03 DRAIN, RESERVING THE LIQUID

Remove the tea bags and any amla pieces. Drain the chickpeas, reserving the dark cooking liquid for adjusting the gravy later.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Chickpeas, continued

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The chickpeas should be very soft, mashable under light pressure, and a deep brown color throughout, not just on the surface.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Amritsari Masala

04 SAUTÉ THE ONIONS

Heat oil or ghee in a kadai and sauté the chopped onion until deeply golden brown, about 8–10 minutes.

05 ADD AROMATICS AND SPICES

Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, anardana powder, amchur, chili powder, and the Amritsari chole masala blend. Simmer for 10–12 minutes until thick and the oil separates.



06 ADD THE CHICKPEAS

Add the cooked chickpeas along with some reserved cooking liquid to reach your preferred consistency. Simmer together for 15–20 minutes, mashing a few chickpeas against the pan to help thicken naturally.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Amritsari Masala, continued

Color and texture indicator. finished Amritsari chole should be notably darker and tangier than standard chole, with a thick, glossy gravy clinging to the chickpeas.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Using standard chole masala powder instead of the more intensely dark-roasted Amritsari-style blend results in a paler, milder dish that misses this style's defining character. Seek out the specifically labeled blend, or roast your own whole spices dark and fragrant.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with Amritsari kulcha, garnished generously with sliced onion, green chili, and julienned ginger.
- A classic Amritsar street food breakfast or lunch, often eaten standing at a stall.

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl with kulcha on the side, a wedge of lemon, and a scoop of onion salad.

Family Style

- A shared pot alongside a stack of kulcha or bhature, letting everyone garnish their own bowl to taste.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Depth Right

- A generous, dark tea simmer and the specific Amritsari spice blend are what genuinely separate this from standard chole — don't shortcut either.
- Anardana's tang is essential to the dish's character — don't substitute it with more chili, which changes the flavor profile entirely.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Like most chole, this dish improves with a day of resting in the refrigerator before serving.
- Make a large batch of the dry-roasted Amritsari spice blend and store it airtight for quick future cooking.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Amritsar street vendors often finish the dish with a small piece of butter stirred in right before serving, adding richness without softening the dish's distinctive tang.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

270 kcal	11 g	37 g	9 g	10 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Delhi-Style Chole	milder and less tangy — see our dedicated Chole Masala recipe card.
Amritsari Chole Kulche	served specifically with stuffed kulcha for the complete street food experience.
Extra-Tangy Amritsari Chole	an even more sour version favored by some street stalls, with extra anardana and amchur.

What makes this different from regular chole?

A darker color from a stronger tea simmer, a tangier flavor from anardana and amchur, and a more intensely roasted spice blend distinguish Amritsari chole from milder Delhi-style versions.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I skip the amla?

Yes — it's a traditional but optional addition. The dish will still be authentic and flavorful without it.

Is Amritsari chole spicier than regular chole?

It's typically tangier more than spicier — adjust chili powder to your own heat preference independent of the tang level.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary

GLOSSARY

Anardana	dried pomegranate seed powder, giving this dish its distinctive tang.
Kulcha	a stuffed, tandoor-baked bread, the classic Amritsari pairing for this dish.
Amla	Indian gooseberry, traditionally added while cooking chickpeas for subtle tang.
Chana	Hindi for chickpeas, the base ingredient of this dish.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Amritsari Chole

15m	8h + 45m
ACTIVE PREP	SOAK + COOK TIME
4	**Med**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

CHICKPEAS

Chickpeas	300 g
Water	as needed
Black tea bags	2–3
Whole dried amla	2–3 pieces
Salt	6 g

AMRITSARI MASALA

Oil or ghee	45 ml
Onion	150 g
Ginger-garlic paste	22 g
Tomatoes	200 g
Anardana powder	3 g
Amchur	3 g
Kashmiri red chili powder	4.5 g
Amritsari chole masala	12 g
Salt	to taste

FOR GARNISH

Onion	40 g
Green chili	2
Fresh ginger	10 g
Lemon wedges	4

METHOD

01 **Soak overnight.** Rinse the dried chickpeas and soak in plenty of water overnight, or at least 8 hours.

02 **Pressure cook with tea and amla.** Drain and pressure cook with fresh water, salt, tea bags, and dried amla if using, for 6–8 whistles, until completely soft and darkly tinted.

03 **Drain, reserving the liquid.** Remove the tea bags and any amla pieces.

04 **Sauté the onions.** Heat oil or ghee in a kadai and sauté the chopped onion until deeply golden brown, about 8–10 minutes.

05 **Add aromatics and spices.** Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, anardana powder, amchur, chili powder, and the Amritsari chole masala blend.

06 **Add the chickpeas.** Add the cooked chickpeas along with some reserved cooking liquid to reach your preferred consistency.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Chickpeas	300 g	
☐	Whole dried amla	2–3 pieces	
☐	Oil or ghee	45 ml	
☐	Ginger-garlic paste	22 g	
☐	Anardana powder	3 g	
☐	Kashmiri red chili powder	4.5 g	
☐	Green chili	2	
☐	Lemon wedges	4	
☐	Black tea bags	2–3	
☐	Salt	see recipe	
☐	Onion	see recipe	
☐	Tomatoes	200 g	
☐	Amchur	3 g	
☐	Amritsari chole masala	12 g	
☐	Fresh ginger	10 g	

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